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Veiled sentiments

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My most profound debt is to the people in the Bedouin community in which I lived, especially the Haj and his wives and children, whose patience I no doubt taxed but who bore me with humor and warmth. They gracefully overlooked my occasional irritable outbursts and my litany of complaints about the fleas and other annoyances of desert life, only to tease me gently when I was feeling better. They accepted me into their lives, cared for me, and taught me by sharing their deepest concerns and the dramas of their everyday world. My memories of the companionship of the long winter evenings huddled around kerosene lanterns and of the moonlit summer nights graced by gentle breezes when we shuffled indoors in our plastic sandals carrying sleeping children, goatskin bags, and the tea tray, after a long, uneventful day of talking, joking, and working or a wild day of minor crises or an exhausting if exhilarating day of wedding celebrations or visiting—all are vivid. The last page of my fieldnotes reads:

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The tents, the sheep, and the goats are all sights I will miss. I am sure I will forget so much of the texture of life, the feeling at the end of the day as we put away the food and pick things up in the semidark. As I sit in my room writing, I hear the muffled sounds of children running and shouting. R. calls out to her daughter. A car approaches the house. It is a quiet life I will miss. There is no loneliness, always someone to sit with. I feel so much part of something here. I don't remember ever feeling that before.

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Indeed, they taught me not only about their way of life, some small part of which I have tried to convey in this book, but also about the joys of a sociable world in which people hug and talk and shout and laugh without fear of losing one another. I hope that too comes across.

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There are a few more people whose influence on my life and work has been profound. Paul Riesman introduced me to anthropology and showed me what it could be. His ideas continue to xiv inspire me and his encouragement to give me faith. If there is any sensitivity or insight in this study, I dedicate it to him. If anyone is responsible for this book being written at all, however, it is my parents. For their belief in me, their contributions, willing and often unwitting, to this particular project, and much more that I cannot begin to detail, I thank them.

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